

EFC SERMON: MALACHI 3:1 “WHERE IS THE GOD OF JUSTICE?”

When God’s People Cry Out, He Hears Us. And He Gives Us What We Need.

A Sermon Outline

English Fellowship Church

Preached on 1 March 2026

by

Jason Douglas Sanderson

jsanderson866@students.sbts.edu

25 February 2026

1. 1 Pet 1:20-25 before worship...

2. SONG Idea: Great is Thy Faithfulness

3. SHORT PERSONAL PRAYER

4. INTRODUCTION

a. Blessings,

5. SCRIPTURE READING

a. We'll be in **Malachi Chapter 3**

b. Malachi is one of the Minor Prophets... God says some Major things through him...

c. Read Malachi 3:1

DISPLAY Malachi 3:1

6. PASSAGE BACKGROUND

a. **Remember, at this point in Scripture** the Israelite tribes have taken sides, divided into Israel and Judah, both were exiled, and much of Judah had returned to the land we call Israel under the supervision of the Persians, and Nehemiah had begun leading the charge to restore the temple and the walls... 2nd Temple... However, this isn't exactly looking like Solomon's temple, or even the tabernacle God had Moses and the Israelites constructed. It's specifications are the same, the chambers and courts and everything look similar... Yet, no stormcloud rested over it, no fire or lightning or wind appeared to display God's dwelling in that place.

b. **And we read in Malachi**, that the Israelites felt forsaken, the priests had abandoned the covenant and offered improper sacrifices... and their hearts just aren't in the relationship. Malachi (which may or may not be the actual name of the prophet) is organized into SIX DISPUTATIONS... each one is Israel making a complaint and God rebuking that complaint with warning and/or divine instruction...

c. **Just before Malachi 3**, Israel cries out, "Where is the God of Justice?" the title of this sermon... So, where is he? Why doesn't his stormcloud rest over the temple?

Why doesn't he show up and right the wrongs of the wicked? How long will he wait to do his justice and restore his people?

- d. Does that sound familiar? Have you ever wondered where God is in the midst of your own circumstances? I know I have... About 15 years ago, I was wondering how God could do this to me, or allow this to happen, and I wanted to know where he was. I had volunteered to go to Afghanistan in the place of an acquaintance in my military unit. He was on track to deploy to fight the Taliban, but his father suddenly got diagnosed with terminal cancer. It didn't take long to think about what I should do. I told the chief of my section I would like to go in his place, and I did. While I was there, I was working the AM shift (from midnight until noon), launching and recovering aircraft mostly. Air dropping weapons and ammunition, transporting soldiers and airmen, and delivering life-saving blood to the most forward medical facilities and front lines. One night before I woke up to go to work, the Chief and the Captain came knocking on my plywood door. They said I needed to turn over my weapons and come with them to make a phone call. It was one of the hardest things they ever had to do and they didn't even know what the call was about. All they knew was I had received a call from the American Red Cross while I was in a war zone. That could only mean one thing... the death of a close family member. It turned out, it was my mom. I couldn't think of a worse person to lose in that moment. This woman who had cared for me, and loved me unconditionally since birth, I was so alone. And I wanted to know why... where was God... how could he allow this... I wanted the God of justice to end the war in Afghanistan, to take away my friend's dad's cancer, and to bring back my mom.

7. POINT #1 **"Behold, I send my messenger, and he will prepare the way before me."** AKA John the Baptist (Mal 3:1a)

- a. This is the answer to the question, "Where is the God of Justice?" from Malachi 2:17. The Lord speaks through his prophet and says "BEHOLD." If you comb through Scripture for this

word, you'll see it used like a Hebrew idiom that basically means, "LOOK OUT!" or "SEE THIS!" or "WATCH!" and its always related to something important, almost always something God is doing in the lives of his people.

- b. **God** says Look! I am sending someone! And he will prepare the way... **DISPLAY my old unit patch.** ~~And out Brig Gen Mounkes.~~ Explain the patch... We had a motto for our unit... some of you may have heard of "that others may live" of the Search and Rescue community... ours was designed by my old mentor and now a retired General officer. Out unit assessed, opened, and operated contingency airfields and airbases in any environment across the globe. It was the first-in unit to "prepare the way" for the big Air Force, or for the contingency operation that was about to take place. Most people didn't notice, but this man was a graduate from the same seminary I have the honor of graduating from later this year... and he slipped in the prophecy from Malachi... "Prepare the Way" became our squadron motto.
- c. To prepare the way before the Lord means the time or place, the setting, wasn't ready for his presence... and the fact that he is sending his messenger means **the people weren't ready**... they needed to hear something before he comes. Their hearts and their lifestyles were not ready for the God of justice. PAUSE. Are you? PAUSE. Or do you need to hear the same message today, that God's messenger brings?
- d. I guess before we answer that question, we need to know who God's messenger is or was and what message he brought or is bringing... **Jump to talking about my sport coat.** Heather and her mom did a special thing for me over Christmas... I said I wanted a nice brown coat to wear and they picked one out for me. Gave it to me when I went home for the holiday... and upon closer examination, I discovered what it was made of... **camel hair.** Do you know who else wore camel hair? That's right, the one who came to prepare the way for the Lord, the voice crying out from the wilderness, none other than John the Baptist... calling for Israel to **Repent for the Kingdom of Heaven is at hand.** Display Matt, Mark, Luke Graphic. The synoptic gospels capture this nicely

8. POINT #2 “Who is the second messenger?” “**And the Messenger of the covenant in whom you delight, behold, he is coming, says the Lord of hosts.**” (Malachi 3:1c)

- a. **The Messenger of the covenant**... who might that be? Well, if we look briefly into the Old Covenants we see the Word of the Lord, the **Angel of the Lord**, and the Name of the Lord... these are ways to describe YHWH coming to his people directly. However, we know our God as a Triune God. Nothing is done by one person of the Trinity in secret from the others, but it does seem that in their relation to one another, we can see a pattern of the Father sending the Son, and the Spirit. This One who is coming, sounds a lot like the One who brought the old covenant to God’s people, and he is coming to renew that covenant for New Covenant believers... this Messenger, friends, is **Jesus**. We see him come immediately following John the Baptist who we know was preparing the way for him.
- b. Most intriguing to me is this **Angel of the Lord** figure who shows up at various points in Scripture and then speaks as if he himself is the LORD speaking. He has authority. Perhaps even the same figure from Joshua’s encounter before the battle of Jericho. It’s important to note, this word Angel, Mal’ak in the Hebrew, and Angelos, in the Greek, is not a word that describes a type of being as much as it is a word that describes a function... the role the person is playing, the duty they have, is a **messenger**. We see seraphim and cherubim not described as angels but other spiritual beings in the heavens and in the throne room of God... In Joshua’s story, a man comes before Joshua, the Bible calls him “sar” in Hebrew, which could be translated prince, captain, or representative of the King. When Joshua bows down, the Commander or Prince of the Lord’s Army does not tell him to get up like ordinary messengers of God do. He accepts his worship and even says where you are standing is holy ground!

DISPLAY JOSHUA 5:14-15

This is the same thing the Angel of the Lord said to Moses from the burning bush.
“Take your sandals off your feet, for the place on which you are standing is holy ground.”

DISPLAY EXODUS 3:2-5

- c. What’s the point? You might be saying... the point is, **these messengers** from the Old Testament are many times, God himself manifesting in some way to intervene in the lives of his people. This is exactly what scholars see happening in this prophecy from Malachi about the messenger of the covenant. **Jesus**. So, did Jesus come to his temple to bring justice? Not yet, right? He came so that we may have life and have it more abundantly (DISPLAY JOHN 10:10) like Jeremy preached last week... he came to seek and save the lost (DISPLAY LUKE 19:10)... he came to give his life as a ransom for many (DISPLAY MARK 10:45).
- d. So, where, then, is the God of justice? Oh, he *is* coming back... don’t forget what we studied last year in Revelation. When he comes back, it will not be pretty, for the unbelieving world. Because **all** have sinned and fallen short of the glory of God (DISPLAY ROMANS 3:23) and the wages of sin is death (DISPLAY ROMANS 6:23)... **this will be his justice for sinners in the final days**. He will separate the wheat from the chaff... and the chaff he will burn with unquenchable fire (DISPLAY MATTHEW 3:12). **Long pause... ..**
- e. But... (read slowly) God shows his love for us in that while we were still sinners, Christ died for us (DISPLAY ROMANS 5:8)... You see, God knew that although his people cried out for justice, what they really needed was his mercy, and what he gave them, and us, was his grace. Jesus, the messenger of the covenant, came to save us ahead of the justice we so deserve. And he calls us to REPENT and BELIEVE in the gospel... (DISPLAY MARK 1:14-15)... before it is too late.

9. POINT #3 “Spirit and power of Elijah” and “**And the Lord whom you seek will suddenly come to his temple.**” (Luke 1:17 and Mal 3:1b)

- a. Malachi 4:5-6 says 5 “Behold, I will send you Elijah the prophet before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes. 6 And he will turn the hearts of fathers to their children and the hearts of children to their fathers...”

DISPLAY MALACHI 4:5-6

- b. So was John the Baptist Elijah reincarnated? Some might say yes because of Matthew 11:13-14... **DISPLAY MATTHEW 11:13-14** Jesus says “he is Elijah who is to come.” But, if we jump to John’s gospel **DISPLAY JOHN 1:20-21** John says he is not the Christ, nor is he Elijah. So, which is it? **DISPLAY LUKE 1:17** Luke’s gospel brings these things together when another messenger from God came to Zechariah and said he will go before Jesus in the **spirit and power** of Elijah... to turn the hearts of the fathers to their children... to make ready for the Lord, a people prepared.
- c. This is Malachi’s prophecy about John the Baptist. And the people would have to wait around 400 years to see it fulfilled... in God’s time. The Lord did not come to his temple until Jesus came into the temple of his human flesh.
- d. How long might you be able to endure? How might you be able to trust the Lord with what he has in store for you now? Are you accepting his grace and his mercy as you cry out also for justice? This isn’t a bad thing to cry out for, yet, if you aren’t willing to change your own heart, or to have it changed by the God who loves you and cares for you, then you’re not ready for justice to be done in your life.
- e. I see people all over social media, the internet, and television pointing at others and screaming about the justice that needs to be done in the lives of others... but what they truly need is God’s grace over their own lives. Unfortunately, they aren’t accepting it in most cases.
- f. That’s where we come in. Church, we must be a people who stands in the gap for others, speaking the truth in love, and demonstrating the fruits of the Spirit by our

- love for one another. We must live out our command to share the gospel, to make disciples, and to teach everything Jesus commanded us. So that others may live. So that they might repent and believe.
- g. The world needs our hope. The hope we have in Christ for the forgiveness of sins as well as the resurrection of our bodies one day. He has given us his grace when what we deserve is his wrath, his justice for our sin. We can rejoice in that display of his love and loyalty. If God is sovereign and in control of everything... and he is good... we can trust him. We can wait on him. We can have hope, and peace, and love, and joy in the midst of our circumstances.
 - h. I didn't understand it before, but now, as I write this on what would be my mom's 68th birthday, I realize God's mercies in taking her when he did. I recognize his grace over my life, and how he's changed me for the better as a result of that horrible day in Afghanistan. If I didn't say goodbye when I left, I would not have gotten a goodbye at all. Because of the suddenness of her death. She even looked at my (soon to be) wife (at the time) and said, "he's your problem now, I don't have to worry about him anymore."

10. CONCLUSION:

- i. How Great is our God? From beginning to end... From Adam, to Abraham, to Malachi, to Jesus. He has planned all along to show us his great mercy and his steadfast love. He chose us before the foundations of the world. And we can trust him now, with our lives. With our desires, our families, and our purposes.

11. PRAYER – thankful hearts for God's grace and mercy...

12. SONG Ideas: How Deep the Father's Love, Jesucristo Basta

13. BENEDICTION: 2 Pet 3:14-18